BETTING BIG ON INFRA

The Modi government wants to put the country on a high-growth trajectory by opening the purse strings for infrastructure development rather than offer palliatives. But effective implementation holds the key to achieving this ambitious objective

By M.G. ARUN, SHWWETA PUNJ & ANILESH S. MAHAJAN



When finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman set out to plan Union Budget 2022-23, the challenges before her were humongous. Top on the list was finding ways and means to create jobs for the 53 million who were unemployed as of December 2021, as per data from the Centre for Monitoring Indian Economy (CMIE). Much of the devastation was caused in 2020-21 when two waves of the pandemic wrecked the Indian economy and pushed it into degrowth—dire straits last experienced only 40 years ago. It had crippled businesses across sectors, more so the MSMEs (Micro, Small & Medium Enterprises) that accounted for the bulk of employment.

Meanwhile, fuel and food inflation reared its ugly head, driven by a steep rise in international prices of crude oil, bring-

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